

4 Abel

The shepherd whose offering pleased God, the first to die, and one who "being dead yet speaketh."

Abel was the second son of Adam and Eve and the first shepherd in Scripture. He brought God the firstborn of his flock and their fat portions, and God accepted him and his gift. His brother Cain, angry and jealous, killed him in the field. Abel never speaks a single recorded word in Genesis. Yet the New Testament calls him righteous, lists him first among the heroes of faith, and says that through his faith he still speaks. His short life raises big questions about worship, faith and justice, and it points ahead to another innocent death whose blood "speaketh better things."

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Hevel</i> , probably meaning "breath" or "vapor"
Family	Son of Adam and Eve; younger brother of Cain (Genesis 4:1–2)
Work	"A keeper of sheep" (Genesis 4:2)
Key places	The field where he was killed (Genesis 4:8)
Key people	Adam, Eve, Cain
Main passages	Genesis 4:2–10, 25
New Testament	Matthew 23:35; Luke 11:50–51; Hebrews 11:4; 12:24; 1 John 3:12

"By faith Abel offered unto God a more excellent sacrifice than Cain, by which he obtained witness that he was righteous, God testifying of his gifts: and by it he being dead yet speaketh."

Hebrews 11:4, KJV

The life of Abel

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Abel. The order below follows the text.

After Eden	● Born to Eve Eve bears Abel after his brother Cain. <i>Genesis 4:2</i>
Grown	● Keeps sheep "Abel was a keeper of sheep, but Cain was a tiller of the ground." <i>Genesis 4:2</i>
Later	● Brings an offering Abel brings the firstlings of his flock and their fat. "The LORD had respect unto Abel and to his offering." <i>Genesis 4:4</i>
In the field	● Killed by Cain Cain talks with Abel, then rises up against him in the field and kills him. <i>Genesis 4:8</i>
Afterward	● His blood cries out God tells Cain that the voice of his brother's blood cries to him from the ground. <i>Genesis 4:10</i>
Later	● Remembered by Eve Eve names Seth as "another seed instead of Abel, whom Cain slew." <i>Genesis 4:25</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Genesis does not explain why Abel's offering was accepted. Hebrews 11:4 says it was offered by faith. Some also note that he brought the firstborn and the best parts.

- 1 **Kept sheep.** He was the first shepherd named in the Bible. *Genesis 4:2*
- 2 **Brought the firstborn and the best.** He offered the firstlings of his flock and the fat of them. *Genesis 4:4*
- 3 **Offered in faith.** His gift was "a more excellent sacrifice," and God counted him righteous. *Hebrews 11:4*
- 4 **Was accepted by God.** The LORD had respect to Abel himself and to his offering. *Genesis 4:4*
- 5 **Died an innocent death.** He was killed by his own brother, the first death recorded in Scripture. *Genesis 4:8*
- 6 **Still speaks.** His blood cried out to God, and his faith still speaks to readers today. *Genesis 4:10; Hebrews 11:4*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Abel.

Old Testament

Genesis 4:2–10	The whole account of his life and death
Genesis 4:25	Eve names Seth in Abel's place
Echoes	Firstborn and fat belong to God (Exodus 13:12; Leviticus 3:16)

New Testament

Matthew 23:35; Luke 11:50–51	"From the blood of Abel unto the blood of Zacharias"
Hebrews 11:4	Abel heads the list of the faithful
Hebrews 12:24	Jesus' blood "speaketh better things than that of Abel"
1 John 3:12	Cain's works evil, "and his brother's righteous"
Echo: John 10:11	The Good Shepherd lays down his life

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Abel bring to God, and how did God respond (Genesis 4:4)?
2. *Understand:* Hebrews says Abel "being dead yet speaketh." What does his life still say?
3. *Apply:* Abel gave God the first and best. What would giving God your first and best look like this week?
4. *Apply:* Abel was righteous and still suffered. How does his story help you when doing right does not seem to pay off?